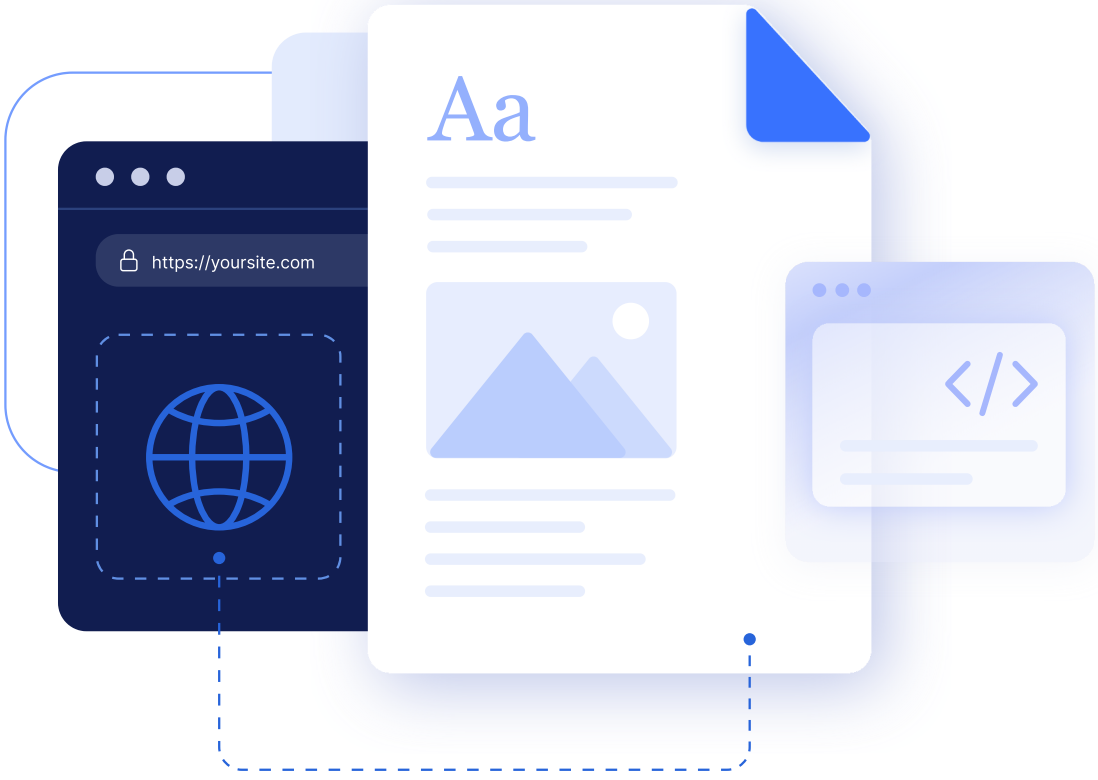
EmbedPDF

OPEN SOURCE
PDF SOLUTIONS

Documents belong on the web.

A short field guide to the past, present and future of PDF.

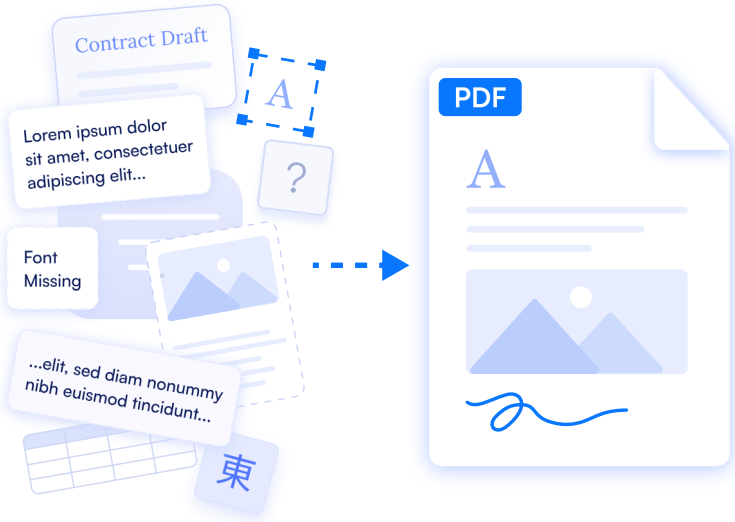
AN EDITORIAL DEMO DOCUMENT FOR EMBEDPDF



ORIGINS

A format from another era

PDF was born out of a simple but stubborn challenge: how do you share a document and keep it looking exactly right, everywhere?



In the late 1980s, moving a document between two computers was a gamble. Fonts went missing, layouts shifted, colours drifted. What printed on one machine rarely matched what appeared on another.

Adobe co-founder John Warnock set out to fix that. The Portable Document Format, introduced in 1993, captured a page as a precise description that was independent of application, operating system and device. It embedded its fonts, carried vector art, and mapped to print with exact fidelity.

It worked. PDF became the dependable way to send contracts, manuals, reports and forms: anything that had to look professional and stay that way.

> The goal was simple: create a digital document that looks the same everywhere.
>
> John Warnock, Adobe co-founder

Real text, not a picture.
Every word here is text, set in the font it was printed with, so it can be searched and copied.

TIMELINE

From paper to pixels.

Key moments that shaped the way we create, share and experience documents.

1980s

Early digital documents

Word processors and portable formats emerge, but compatibility remains a challenge.

1993

PDF is born

Adobe launches PDF, a universal format that preserves layout, fonts and fidelity.

Late 1990s

The web makes it global

PDF becomes the default format for sharing across email, web and operating systems.

2000s

Standards and accessibility

ISO standardization and accessibility features make documents more reliable and inclusive.

2010s

Browser-native viewing

PDF viewing goes native in browsers and devices, with no plugins required.

Today

Component-driven experiences

APIs and embeddable components bring documents to life inside modern apps.

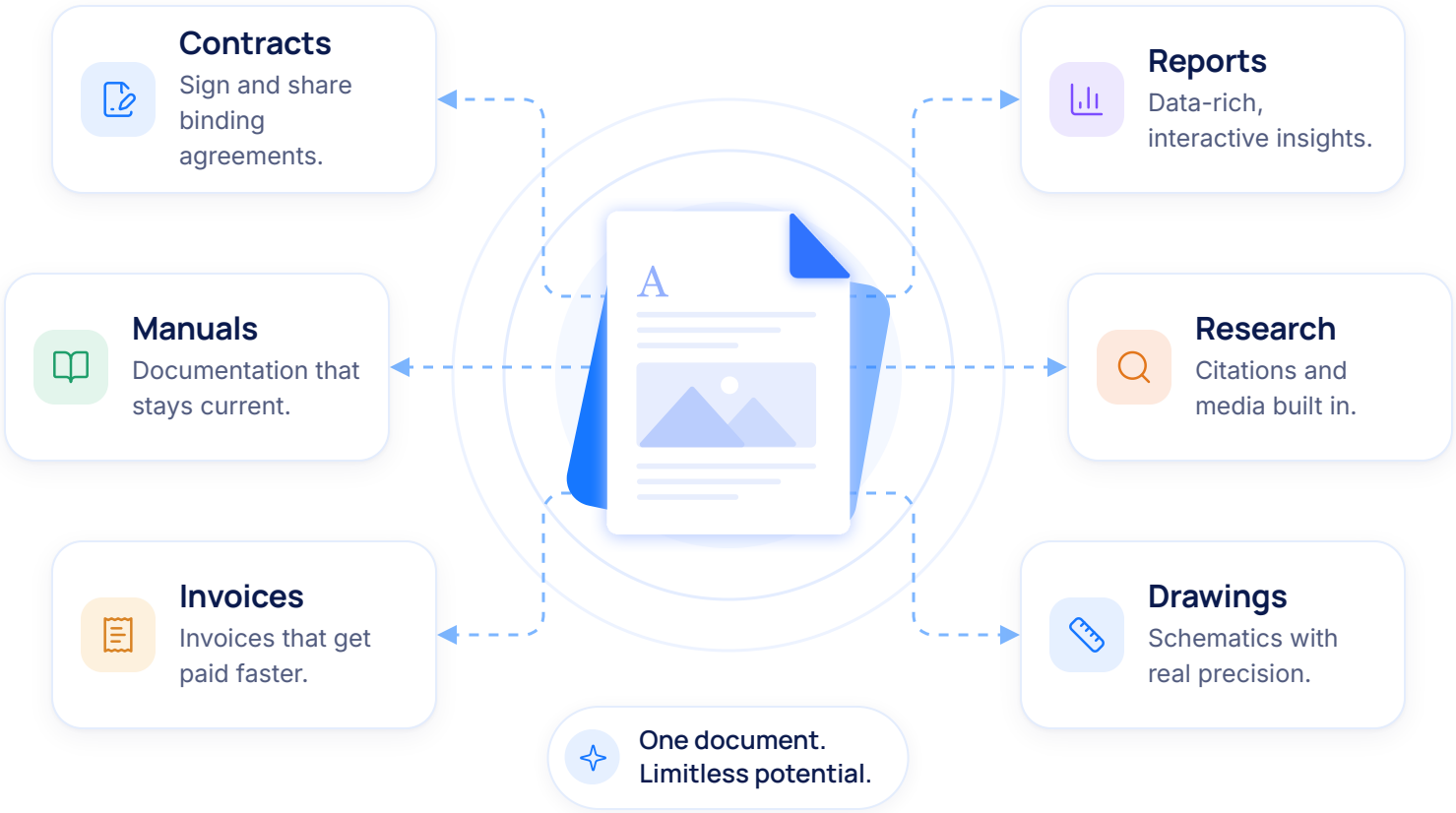
Sharp at any size.

Text and vectors are drawn live, so nothing here turns into pixels.

WORKFLOWS

1 document, 1,000 workflows

One modern document format.
Every team. Every system. Every time.



For every team
Marketing, Sales, Legal, Finance.

For every system
Embed once. Integrate everywhere.

For everywhere
Web, mobile, portal or app.